

The full plan

The 90-Day Owner-Independence Test

The real question isn't "can I take a holiday?" It is: can the business make routine decisions, serve customers, collect cash, pay obligations, manage people, resolve problems and protect itself for 90 days — without relying on the owner's knowledge, authority, relationships or presence?

Framed that way, this stops being a leave planner and becomes a measure of business maturity, resilience, scalability and — ultimately — saleability. A buyer pays for a business that runs; not for a job that depends on you.

The one test that matters. For every item, don't ask "do I do this?" — ask "can this happen without me?"

What your 90-Day Test score means

Score	Label	What it tells you
0–39	Self-Employed	The business is you — an unplanned week away would already cause problems.
40–64	Owner-Reliant	It runs, but leans on you for approvals; it could cope for a few days, not 90.
65–84	Owner-Light	Strong foundations — could hold for a few weeks. Close the remaining gaps.
85–100	Owner-Independent	A business, not a job. Decisions happen without you, up to clear limits.

Score maturity, not paperwork

A ticked box that says "an SOP exists" proves nothing. Score every item on how far it has actually travelled from you:

Level	State	Meaning
0	Owner-dependent	Nobody else can do it.
1	Documented	The process or authority exists on paper.
2	Delegated	Another named person is trained and authorised.
3	Proven	They have actually done it, without you, more than once.

RAG per area: ■ Red (avg < 1.0) — still owner-dependent, fix first. ■ Amber (1.0–1.9) — on paper or partly delegated, not yet safe. ■ Green (2.0+) — delegated, heading to proven. Proven beats documented every time.

The spine: the Authority Matrix (build this first)

For every recurring decision, answer four questions — not just "who has authority": **Who can decide?** → **Up to what limit?** → **What must be documented?** → **When must it escalate?** And add the column most matrices miss — **Reserved Matters:** decisions that should never simply fall to whoever is on duty.

Decision	Authority	Limit	Escalate to	Reserved?
Customer refund	Service Manager	R10,000	GM	No
Sales discount	Sales Manager	7.5%	GM	No
Capex	GM	R100,000	Owner / Board	Above limit

New borrowing	—	—	Owner / Board	Yes
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Reserved Matters typically include: substantial debt; a major or long-term contract; buying or selling a major asset; settling material litigation; changing shareholder arrangements; unusually large capex; changing banking facilities; hiring or firing very senior people.

No new single point of failure. Removing dependence on the owner must not simply create dependence on the deputy. Every business-critical responsibility needs a primary owner and a capable backup.

Part A — Survival Layer (the 10 that decide whether you survive 90 days at all)

If any one still requires you, the business stalls within days. Aim for all ten at level 3 before any real absence.

- **1. Authority Matrix exists** — who can decide/spend/approve/discount/refund/hire/extend credit, to what limit, what's logged, when it escalates, and which matters are reserved.
- **2. Payments can be released without you** — payroll and suppliers up to a set limit.
- **3. A sale can be closed without you** — quote, discount within rules, accept an order.
- **4. A customer problem can be resolved without you** — complaint + refund/credit to a limit.
- **5. Stock/supplies can be reordered without you** — raise a PO, approve a supplier invoice to a limit.
- **6. People matters can be handled without you** — leave, a shift gap, minor discipline.
- **7. Authorised access survives without you** — no critical system depends on your personal login, device or MFA; named accounts, banking mandates, password-manager emergency access, backup MFA.
- **8. Escalation works — including when you can't be reached** — what genuinely needs you, a way to reach you, and a predefined emergency authority for when you're unreachable.
- **9. A weekly numbers rhythm** — a short exception scorecard the team runs without you.
- **10. Cash keeps coming in without you** — someone owns debtor follow-up: enforce terms, place on stop, negotiate an approved arrangement, escalate material overdue accounts.

Part B — Comprehensive Layer (10 dimensions, scored 0–3)

1. Decision Rights & Authority

- Written Authority Matrix with a Reserved Matters column
- A named deputy — and a backup for the deputy
- Everyone knows what they can decide alone vs escalate
- A rule for the unknown case (under R__ judge & log; over R__ hold)

2. Sales, Quoting & Pricing

- Documented price list / rate card and discount rules
- Pre-approved quote, contract and T&C; templates
- A rule for accepting a new customer without your sign-off
- Someone owns lead follow-up while you're away

3. Customer Service & Resolution

- Documented complaints policy; refund/credit authority to a limit
- Escalation path to the deputy, not straight to you

- Key customer relationships known to more than one person
- A response-time standard (e.g. reply within 24h)

4. Collections & Credit Control

- Who approves credit limits — without you
- Who can change terms / place an account on stop
- Who follows overdue debt and can negotiate an arrangement
- The amount/age at which overdue debt escalates

5. Money & Payments

- Approve and release payments up to a limit without you
- Payroll runs and is approved without you present
- A second banking mandate (not owner-only)
- Someone can tell you the cash position at any time

6. Purchasing & Suppliers

- Preferred supplier list, terms and contacts known to more than one person
- Documented reorder rules; PO/invoice approval to a limit
- A process for a supplier problem without you

7. People, Operations & Delivery

- A manager handles leave, rosters and first-line discipline
- Core work in simple SOPs with written quality standards
- Every key role has a cross-trained backup
- Recurring tasks have owners and a schedule

8. Access, IT & Cyber Resilience

- Password manager with emergency access; no reliance on your device/MFA
- Banking via mandates held by more than one person
- Keys, contracts, insurance, licences stored where the team can find them
- A written IT/cyber incident plan (outage, ransomware, lost phone, failed backup, payment fraud): who acts, who authorises spend, where backups are, who tells customers

9. Compliance & Obligations

- Tax and statutory submissions happen without you
- Insurance renewals, licences and permits diarised and owned
- Contract renewal and notice dates tracked
- Someone knows what must be reported to insurers, regulators, lenders or partners

10. Rhythm, Escalation & Continuity

- A weekly exception scorecard the deputy runs

- A clear escalation path including an emergency authority if you're unreachable
- Written 'if this happens, do this' steps for your top crises

Running through all of it — External Relationships

Owner-dependence often hides in relationships, not processes. For each of these, is the history known to more than one person, and is someone other than you authorised to deal with them? **Bank · accountant/auditor · lawyer · insurance broker · landlord · major funder · key technology provider · outsourced payroll · major strategic partner.**

The weekly scorecard (an exception dashboard, not a management pack)

Area	What it answers
Cash	Bank/cash available · near-term cash requirement · overdue receivables
Revenue	Sales / order intake · pipeline or backlog
Margin	Gross margin / contribution
Delivery	Orders / jobs / projects overdue
People	Serious staffing issues
Risk	Major customer, supplier or quality incidents

The real test (and how to record it)

The progression stays: one week → two weeks → one month → 90 days, each with your phone off. But don't just note what broke — every time you're absent, record three things:

Symptom	What it reveals
What stopped ?	A process / capability failure
What waited ?	An authority failure
What came back to you ?	A delegation / culture failure

The brutal rule: if the owner answers a question that someone else should have been able to answer, the test failed at that point. Otherwise owners quietly keep rescuing the business and wrongly conclude it passed.

Owner: _____ Deputy: _____ Deputy's backup: _____ Date: _____

General management framework; not accounting, tax, legal or other professional advice specific to your business. Contact: info@carron.co.za